

The Psalter is about Christ

The Psalter teaches us how to pray

Psalm 1 – Blessed is the man

All sins come from a progression of thought

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For centuries, the church's personal prayer book was only the Psalter. Now we have prayer books, which are basically abbreviations of canonical services in the Horologion (the Horologion means "Book of the Hours", and contains the services done every day, Midnight Office, Vespers, Matins, etc.). Many people only know morning and evening prayers and have no idea that **the church has always considered the Psalter to be the model for how to pray**. You cannot find a church service that does not have either entire Psalms verbatim or parts of Psalms or allusions to them. They are truly ubiquitous.

The Orthodox Psalter is divided into 20 chapters. We call these "Kathismas" because when they are read in the church people sit and that Greek word means sit. Each Kathisma is divided into three subsections, each of which we call a "stasis". It is a very good personal rule to read some Psalms every day and read in such a way that you read the entire Psalter in some fixed period of time.

The Psalter is about Jesus Christ. Many of the Psalms describe Him, and many of them are actually His words. Of course, by His words I mean not that He said them explicitly, but that they are in His person. The Psalter also describes every emotional and spiritual state of man, and the solution to those conditions. **It teaches us how to approach God in prayer.** There is humility in the Psalms. There is also zeal, and forcefulness, and even complaining. It is not wrong to tell God what is wrong, but we must tell Him in a particular way. The Psalms show us this way. The Psalms show that for every problem, God is the only solution.

It is truly impossible to consider any of the church's prayer without understanding that it is shaped by the Psalter.

Psalm 1 – Blessed is the man.

This Psalm is called: **"Blessed is the man"**, because those are the first few words of the Psalm. We name many prayers by their first few words. Another example would be the "Our Father".

This Psalm is a description of Jesus Christ. It is also a description of the way of life that leads to eternal life.

The Psalm begins: **"Blessed is the man that hath not walked in the counsel of the ungodly, nor stood in the way of sinners, nor sat in the seat of the pestilent."** 1:1.

There is a story from the Desert Fathers of a man who heard this verse and immediately left to go into the desert in order to learn what it means and didn't come back until 20 years later. Truly, the entire Gospel and the entire way of "life" is encapsulated in this verse. The character of Jesus Christ is also described in this verse.

The Psalter is full of beautiful Hebrew poetry. A very common aspect of Hebrew poetry is something called a couplet. When something is said, it is said again, in a slightly different way. Our Lord preached with many couplets. They are all over the Scriptures. Sometimes in a couplet, something is said and then the opposite of it is said.

Here is an example of a couplet. "Have mercy and me, O God according to thy great mercy, and according to the multitude of thy compassions blot out my transgressions" (Psalm 50:1). Here, David is asking for mercy and then is asking for mercy again in a more exact way - "blot out my transgressions".

An example of a couplet in which the opposite is said is right from this Psalm: **“For the Lord knoweth the way of the righteous, and the way of the ungodly shall perish.”** (Psalm 1:6) Certainly those whom the Lord does not “know” are those who perish.

Every verse in this Psalm is a couplet, or “more”. The first verse of this Psalm is actually a triplet. It also shows a progression of how to live righteously, and if we take it in another sense, how those who are sinners do not live, and how sin grows in us.

All sins come from a progression of thought

There is always a progression in our souls when we sin. All sin starts with thought. There are many thoughts in our minds. Some of them are from our own mind, some are because of our passions, others are from outside and suggested from other people or from demons, or in the case of good thoughts, from the Holy Spirit and our Guardian Angel.

When a sinful thought is suggested to our mind, we can reject it out of hand, or begin to, as the Father’s say “entertain” it. It is always safest to reject a sinful thought immediately. Those who are practiced in the spiritual life may reject a sinful thought before even becoming aware of it. Others, such as our sinful selves, may recognize a sinful thought, and then reject it. Once we become aware of the thought and we have not rejected it outright, our mind begins to consider it. If we consider it for too long, our passions will feel an attraction to it, and then give into it. It is possible to reject a thought after considering it, and even after feeling an attraction to it, but the latter becomes harder to do, close to impossible.

The Psalm is describing the progression of sinful thoughts in the soul before we actually sin. Three levels of association are given, each one an increase over the other. One level of association is **walking** with something that is sinful, that is, at least allowing it into the heart to be considered. Another is to **stand** with something sinful; that indicates, if not acceptance, the beginning of acceptance of the thought. When we have fully accepted the thought, we **sit** down with it.

Of course, we are in the world, and we are all around sinful things. If we decided we would not be around any sinners, we would not go to work, nor would we shop at any store, nor would we even tolerate being around ourselves and our family. It is not a sin to be around people that are sinful, but it is a sin to walk with them, to stand with them, and to sit with them. We are Christians and we should only accept the things that are just and good and honest and holy. It is important to recognize that the choices we make may lead to worse choices. Walking with sinners will inevitably lead to standing with them and finally sitting down with them.

Certainly, Jesus Christ, who sought out sinners and talked to them and helped them, never walked with them, nor stood with them, nor sat with them. St. Paul tells us that He was like us in all ways, except that He did not sin. This is how we should act also. Of course, this is a high bar, and quite impossible for us in this life, at least in our current sinful condition. That is no excuse for us, however. We believe that there are men and women who actually became completely purified even in this life. They took the words of this Psalm to heart.

The second verse introduces the law of the Lord, something much misunderstood in our day. It says:” But **his will is rather in the law of the Lord, and in His law will he meditate day and night.**” (1:2)

Certainly, this describes the character of our Lord Jesus Christ, Whose will was always to obey His Father. He meditated on the law, day and night.

In our benighted world, law is thought of as something that is imposed on a person as a punishment. Even people who believe in Christ believe that God’s law is something that punishes. There are many that believe that God’s law, and His absolute holiness forced Him to find a pure perfect sacrifice that would pay the punishment that is inevitable when one breaks the law. This is called the so-called “substitutionary atonement”, a new idea of only a few hundred years, and quite foreign to Orthodox theology. We do not believe that Jesus Christ came in order to be punished so that we would not be punished. We believe that He came in order for us to be able to defeat death and be healed.

The law of God is actually a reflection of Who God is. Since we are made in God’s image, we are like Him in some way, and it stands to reason that the only way to live that will bring us happiness and growth is to live according to His law, because **following His law is natural to the image of God that is within us.** This is why we follow the law of God – to love our

neighbor, to forgive, do not steal, to not fornicate, and all the other things that are spoken of in the Scripture. None of these things are external commands that are imposed upon us. They were all the way of life because they are reflections of who God is.

Many people have the idea that meditation is to sit down and think about something. Sometimes they use their imagination, and this is something that the church has always considered to be dangerous. If we want to meditate upon God's law, we should first try to follow it, and also read it and pray it. **There is no better way to read about God's law and to pray it than to read the Psalter with attention.** This is a kind of meditation upon God's law. Of course, if we read without the intent to do, there is no meditation upon the law, but merely a blasphemous wasting of time.

Our Lord Jesus Christ meditated on the law by following it perfectly. We also should attempt to do this. That is the primary way we meditate upon the law.

The next verse is not only a description of how our Lord lived on this earth, but also a promise of baptism and resurrection. The verse says this: **"And he shall be like the tree which is planted by the streams of the waters, which shall bring forth its fruit in its season; and its leaf shall not fall, and all things whatsoever he may do shall prosper."** 1:3

Of course, the primary task of Jesus Christ was to live, and die, and resurrect so that we could be resurrected. He had other aims also: the showing of the way to live by example, the gathering of disciples, the forming of the church. Truly in all these things, He prospered.

We are also that tree that is planted by the streams of the waters, that new creature that arises out of the waters of baptism, and we are also called to bring forth fruit in its season. The promise of baptism, if we try to live righteously, is that our leaf shall not fall. A leaf falls when it dies. Death is defeated by Jesus Christ. Even though our flesh will likely die, in the next life we will be resurrected and be with the Lord.

Verse four describes the ungodly, but we make a huge mistake if we think it does not also describe things that *we do*.

"Not so are the ungodly, not so; but rather they are like the chaff which the wind doth hurl away from the face of the earth. For this reason shall the ungodly not stand up in judgement, nor sinners in the council of the righteous." (1:4,5)

The chaff is useless (inedible) material that encapsulates the wheat. It is removed by throwing the wheat into the air on a windy day, and the lighter chaff is blown away, while the heavier wheat falls down directly to the ground. Anytime we do things that are sinful, or our own will, we are doing things that are chaff. We should attempt to do things that are permanent. The only permanent things are things that are according to the law of God.

"For the Lord knoweth the way of the righteous, and the way of the ungodly shall perish." 1:6

The last verse is a promise to the righteous and to the wicked. The wicked will perish, but the Lord "will know the way of the righteous". This is an intimate word – "know". A person cannot know someone without becoming like them in some way and sharing in their life. It is also this way with God. We cannot know Him unless we become like Him. The entire reason for the incarnation, the passion, the resurrection and the sending of the Holy Spirit and the formation of the church is so that we can become like God and know Him.

This article is an excerpt from a longer "Prison Visit Report", part of our prison ministry. WE often write reports on the subjects talked about in prison ministry visits. The full report is at:

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(We visit 5 prisons regularly, and have monthly expenses exceeding one thousand dollars)